

The UK Linguistics Olympiad 2018

Solution and marking.

Scoring

- 4.1. 1 point for each correct cell (max 7)
- 4.2. 2 points for each correct answer (max 20)
 - 1 point with one wrong letter.

4.1	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
	a	d	e	h	g	f	c	b
4.2	a. xakǔnú				b. xañíʔní			
	c. Kuʔu Maria.				d. Kwáá Pedro.			
	e. Pedro kúu ï xakwáá.				f. Kwaʔá saʔma.			
	g. Saʔmarí kúu xatûû.				h. Kaa ndáa.			
	i. Ndáa.				j. Kúu xandáa.			

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Commentary

This problem is based on several features of Chalcatongo Mixtec – however, for the purposes of the problem, some of the tasks & the discussion below have been simplified.

1. Two copulas:

Chalcatongo Mixtec has two verbs that can be used as copulas: *kúu* and *kaa*.

- *Kúu* is used when the predicate is a noun phrase, as in example sentence 2: *Maria kúu # xasiʔi*. = Maria is a woman.
- However, when the predicate consists of an adjective, the copula is *kaa*. This can be seen in example sentence 4: *Juan kaa lúli*. = Juan is short / small.

2. The copula “kaa” as optional & its role in adding emphasis to the subject as sentence topic:

The copula *kaa* is also optional – as example sentences 1 and 3 demonstrate. Sentence 1 features the copula *kaa*. *Nduča kaa ñiʔní*. – this means that the subject of the sentence, *nduča*, is stressed or emphasised. The speaker is referring to a particular volume of water, whereas in sentence 3, the copula *kaa* can be omitted: *Ñiʔní nduča*. In this case, the speaker is not emphasising a particular volume of water, they are not putting any emphasis on the water as topic & subject of this sentence.

Interestingly, the word order (which is mostly VSO in Chalcatongo Mixtec, but not consistently) changes when the copula *kaa* is omitted, the predicate (adjective) precedes the subject.

3. Nominalization: making nouns out of adjectives

By adding the prefix *xa-* to an existing adjective, you can create a noun with a similar meaning as the original adjective. In example sentence 6: the adjective *siʔi* translates as “feminine”, while in example sentence 2: *Maria kúu # xasiʔi*, a new noun has been formed by adding *xa* to *siʔi*, creating the noun “woman”.

4. Possessive marker –rí:

The suffix *-rí* can be added to the end of a noun to express first person singular possessive (i.e. “my” or “mine”). Example sentence 8 demonstrates this: *Pedro kúu xalúlírí*. Here the original adjective *lúli* (small, short) has become a noun through having the nominalizer *xa-* prefixed (making it mean “child”) and the adding of the suffix *-rí* can be translated as the possessive determiner “my”.

References:

- Macaulay, M. (2002). The syntax of Chalcatongo Mixtec Preverbal and postverbal. In Carnie, A, Harley, H & Dooley, S. A. (Eds), *Verb First. On the syntax of verb initial languages* (pp.). Philadelphia: John Benjamins Publishing Company.
- Macaulay, M. (1993). Argument Status and Constituent Structure in Chalcatongo Mixtec. *Proceedings of the annual meeting of the Berkeley Linguistics Society*, 19(2), 73-85.

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<https://www.ethnologue.com/language/mig>